

BEFORE

On the eve of European conquest, three highly advanced civilizations occupied much of Central and South America.

MAYANS

The Mayan states **140–41** clustered around the Yucatán Peninsula in what is now southeast Mexico. All **16 states were independent**, and in 1480 there was a major war for regional supremacy. The lack of a single ruler made these states more difficult to conquer.

AZTECS

The Aztec Empire **210–13** was based around the city of Tenochtitlán (on the site of present-day Mexico City). Under Itzcoatl (reigned 1428–40) and his successors, the empire expanded rapidly, so that by the reign of Moctezuma II (1502–20), **over 10 million people** were subject to Aztec rule, which stretched from the Caribbean across the valley of Mexico. Central to their belief system was the need to provide human sacrifices for their sun god Huitzilopochtli.



15th CENTURY MAP OF TENOCHTITLÁN

INCAS

During the reigns of Pachacuti (1438–71) and his son Tupac Yupanqui (1471–93), the Inca empire, established around 1230 in the South American Andes, grew rapidly **210–15**. By 1525, the empire was at its greatest extent, stretching from modern-day Ecuador in the north to Chile in the south. The empire was **rich in gold** and had a 12,500-mile (20,000-km) network of roads.

GOLD INCA KNIFE



“Shipmates and friends. There lies **the hard way**, leading to Peru and wealth.”

FRANCISCO PIZARRO, ON GORGONA ISLAND OFF THE PACIFIC COAST OF COLOMBIA, 1526

Contact Americas

Forty years after Columbus first set foot in the Americas, the Spanish had built a vast empire in North, Central, and South America. With remarkable ingenuity and treachery, and considerable bravery, two small bands of soldiers felled two mighty empires and initiated three centuries of Spanish rule.



The Spanish came to the Americas for a variety of reasons. They sought wealth in the form of gold, spices, and other goods. They came to claim land for their king, and saw the locals as inferiors to be subdued and exploited. They came to convert, for in their eyes this was a godless continent. And they came for adventure—Vasco de Balboa was an unsuccessful pig breeder, Hernán Cortés a failed law student—but the Americas gave men such as these a chance of gold and glory. Initial conquest and settlement was

confined to the Caribbean islands. The first permanent mainland settlements were founded from 1510 and included Vasco de Balboa, soon to become the first European to see the Pacific, and Francisco Pizarro. Balboa found gold, and learned of a rich land across the Pacific called Birú (Peru). By now, the Spanish were realizing that this new world was rich, but its wealth was not to be taken easily. In 1518 the Spanish governor of Cuba sent 11 ships under the command of Cortés to explore the coast of the Yucatán peninsula for gold. Cortés learned of a great empire inland,

and on August 16, 1519 set out from the Mexican coast with 15 horsemen, 400 soldiers, and a few hundred porters. Using local guides and interpreters, he arrived at Tlaxcala, an independent city and enemy of the Aztec empire. With the Tlaxacalan army as willing allies, he approached the Aztec capital, Tenochtitlán, in November 1519.

▷ **Spanish stronghold**

The Spanish fort of San Lorenzo del Chagres was built on the Caribbean coast of Panama and guarded the route across the isthmus to the Pacific Ocean.